

turistas altogether. But if you get it, it will probably appear and disappear during the first week. After that you should feel fine.

In 1985 John Howells and Don Merwin wrote a book called *Choose Mexico—Retiring on \$400 a Month*.^{*} The \$400 figure comes from a poll of retired Americans living in Mexico. Howells and Merwin found that the median retired American spends \$250 on housing. Many rents are in the \$150 to \$200 range. Food costs \$150 a month, including meals in restaurants for about \$3 a person. Maids cost 60 cents an hour, the government keeps gas prices low, and for \$100 or less national airlines will sell you local, one-week package tours to Guadalajara, San Miguel de Allende, Taxco, or other spots you may want to visit.

The authors of *Choose Mexico* emphasize that you can live a full, active life on \$400 a month. Those who seldom travel or go out to eat live on \$300 or even \$200 a month. The authors use \$400 because that's what they spend. They thought it would be presumptuous for them to advise others on a lifestyle they have not experienced. But with very little effort you can live for less than \$400.

Perhaps the best bargains Americans find in Mexico are rents. Low rents result from overbuilding during the boom years of the late 1970s and from the large number of retired Americans there who want to rent out their homes for short periods. Interested in a furnished, two-bedroom apartment in Acapulco with a view of the ocean? Figure on \$200 a month. How about colonial, artistic San Miguel de Allende, with its huge American population, in the mountains just four hours from Mexico City? Rent a two-bedroom apartment beginning at \$125 furnished, \$100 unfurnished; or a house for \$250. You prefer the Yucatán peninsula, with

^{*}*Choose Mexico—Retiring on \$400 a Month* costs \$8.95. You can get it from Gateway Books, 66 Cleary Court, Suite 1405, San Francisco, CA 94109. Phone (415) 821-3440.